YPSE

EEDS TO BE DONE



CAPITAL PUNISHMENT Kartavya Path shrouded in smog, Nov. 27

Photograph: ANI

Delhiites now know everything there is to know about pollution in their city. It's a multilayered curse: vehicular and industrial emissions, construction dust and burning of waste, topped each winter with smoke that blows in from farm fires in Punjab and Haryana. No less than the Chief Justice of India, Justice Surya Kant, complained of the effects of pollution, recounting how a 55-minute walk in the late November air had left him gasping for breath.

Concerned citizenry did break out in protest: a crowd of 400 gathered on the India Gate lawns in November flashing placards demanding 'Smog se Azadi' and declaring 'Breathing Is Killing Me'. But the protests ended with a few arrests. The government juggled its GRAP (Graded Response Action Plan) norms: with stricter actions kicking in at earlier stages. A month before, on October 23, the PMO had gathered top bureaucrats from eight central ministries and five states for an emergency review. With the current action plan based on pollution data which is seven years old, P.K. Mishra, principal secretary to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, instructed updates of emissions inventories, alongside focused dust control on major roads and flagged 'overage' vehicles, non-compliant industries and the missed landfill and road-dust clean-up targets.

On December 6, Delhi chief minister Rekha Gupta formed an expert group on air pollution mitigation, chaired by Leena Nandan, retired Union environment secretary. With retired officials of the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) and IIT professors forming the 11-member group, it has been mandated to "discuss scientific solutions as well as other actions, distilling a lot of practical, implementable ideas into recommendations", Nandan told INDIA TODAY.

Trouble is, Delhi has heard all this before.

The previous Aam Aadmi Party government went hoarse citing its record: of closing coal plants, switching industries to piped natural gas, increasing green cover. Delhi does burn little coal now, and many factories use cleaner fuel. But that is precisely Delhi's paradox: never has a city done so much for its air, yet had it worsen so relentlessly.

Of the eight pollutants the air quality index (AQI) measures, the most notorious is PM2.5—particulate matter with a diameter of 2.5 micrometres or less. It makes up to 60 per cent of Delhi's pollution as winter temperature inversions lock the polluted air nearer